

Dahl 1972 RG Notes

Dahl, Robert A. *Polyarchy: Participation and Opposition*.
New Haven: Yale University Press, 1971.

1 Main Idea

2 General Notes

- “Given a regime in which the opponents of the government cannot openly and legally organize into political parties in order to oppose the government in free and fair elections, what conditions favor or impede a transformation into a regime in which they can? That is the question with which this book is concerned.”
- Democratization and development of a public opposition are separate forces. We consider two metrics: the extent to which an opposition is allowed to reasonably exist, and the size of the franchise granted government participation. Two dimensions become public contestation and the right to participate

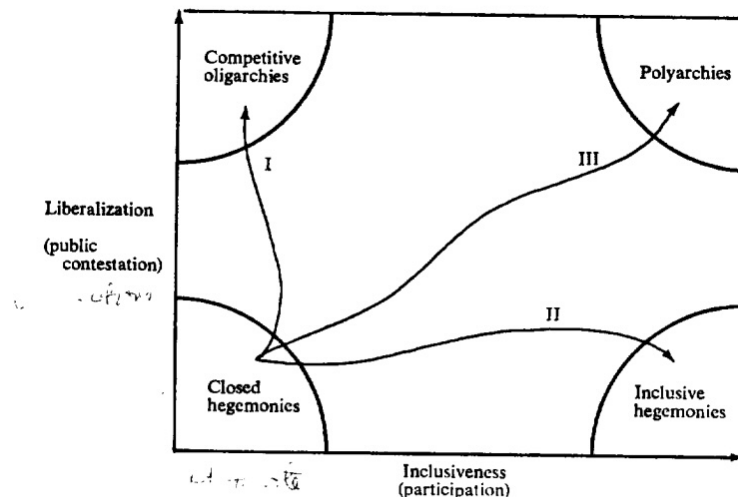


FIGURE 1.2 Liberalization, Inclusiveness, and Democratization

Democratization represented by path III

- “The greater the conflict between government and opposition, the more likely that each will seek to deny opportunities to the other to participate effectively in policy making. To put it another way, the greater the conflict between a government and its opponents, the more costly it is for each to tolerate each other”

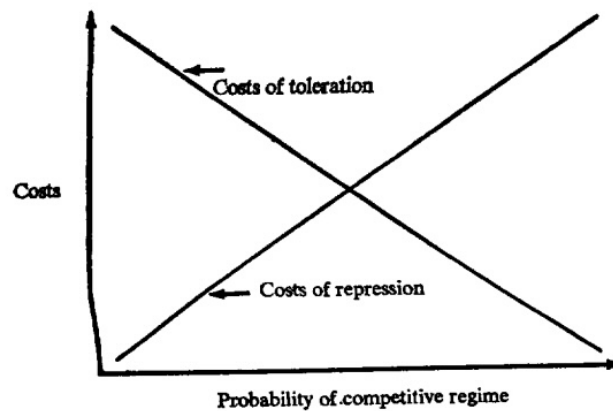


FIGURE 1.4

- As the franchise expands, candidates change their alignments/platforms/beliefs: need to seek support of the newly-enfranchised groups. May often result in the formation of new parties (especially workers'/Labour parties or the like, as well as socialist sentiment) to appeal to these groups. Also drives a change in the structures of parties, as they need to be able to better connect with a larger group: introduces hierarchy, bureaucracy, etc.
- Three primary paths to polyarchy:
 1. Liberalization precedes inclusiveness: England, Sweden. Most common, more peaceful as groups slowly integrate and existing ties hold cohesion. Supported by mutual security that exists at the beginning, and then can be maintained. (Very close to A&R “Why the West...”)
 2. Inclusiveness precedes liberalization: Wiemar Republic. Less common and more dangerous: mutual security system does not exist at the beginning of the process, and so instability may perpetuate.
 3. Shortcut: closed hegemony abruptly transforms into a polyarchy by a sudden grant of suffrage and rights of contestation. France 1789-1792. Few examples of working; no mutual security and little time to adapt to things. (Extremely reflective of Huntington argument, although Dahl focuses more on the lack of mutual security rather than a lack of expressive participatory opportunities)
- Polyarchies often “inaugurated” either within an independent nation-state (transformed via reform, revolution, or military conquest) or in a dependent country subject to another state (transformed via reform or revolution). Peace lends future stability: polyarchies developed through reform are more likely to be viewed as legitimate

- Because suppression requires resources (both for violent and nonviolent means), regimes with limited resources may be more likely to tolerate the opposition, as the relative costliness of intolerance increases. This is counterintuitive in many senses to existing arguments that wealth would drive stability: rather, wealth drives state capacity, which in turn allows for repression/hegemony.
- Effective and dispersed government requires that means of repression/violence/etc. are available to *both* the government and the opposition: asymmetric availability results in monopolistic governance while symmetric unavailability results in uniformity (but could perhaps be more unstable, depending). Ideal for dispersement/neutralization for *both* access to violence and access to socioeconomic sanctions; hegemony thrives when both are monopolized
- While classic liberal theory suggested that competitive politics could not be sustained without competitive market-based economics, Dahl disagrees that this universally holds true – rather, the motivating factor in hegemony is whether or not there is a highly centralized economy (which is itself dissuaded by competitive politics)
- “The chances that a country will develop and maintain a competitive political regime (and, even more so, a polyarchy) depend up on the extent to which the country’s society and economy:
 1. Provide literacy, education, and communication
 2. Create a pluralistic rather than a centrally dominated social order
 3. Prevent extreme inequalities
 among the politically relevant strata of the country.”
- Polyarchy arises out of advanced economies, but advanced economies also may be more prone to severe inequality.
 - One argument here involves the distribution of political resources and skills. Those with the means to do so will attempt to bend political systems in their favor; the distribution of those means is itself endogenous and largely favors to those with the means in the first place. Advanced economies lead to less inequality of political resources – does not imply strict equality, but does imply parity, which in turn supports both inclusion and contestation
 - Alternative explanation suggests that the driving force here is the power of resentment from excluded groups. Regimes may capitulate to *some* demands for greater equality, but not necessarily all; doing so may be sufficient to gain the support of excluded groups even if full equality is not actually achieved. Possible “performative” or signaling impact here
- The effectiveness of polyarchy is largely driven by a belief in its legitimacy. Three propositions here:

1. “The greater the belief within a given country in the legitimacy of the institutions of polyarchy, the greater the chances for polyarchy.”
 2. “Countries vary a great deal in the extent to which activists (and others) believe in the legitimacy of polyarchy.”
 3. “These variations are to some extent independent of the social and economic characteristics of a country: two countries with a great many similarities in their social and economic orders may vary significantly in the extent to which activists (and others) believe in the legitimacy of polyarchy.”
- Trust is a fundamental component of a successful polyarchy. Citizens must be able to effectively communicate, which requires trust. But, more notably, polyarchy requires that political actors trust their opponents (essentially lowering the stakes of political loss): a trust that if the opposition takes power, they will neither impede my ability to lawfully gain back power in the future nor violate my rights/standing/etc. in the meantime. The stakes *need* to be lowered in order to sustain cooperation.

3 Important Specific Factual Claims

- Three necessary conditions for democracy – citizens must be able to:
 1. Formulate their preferences
 2. Signify their preferences to their fellow citizens and the government by individual and collective action
 3. Have their preferences weighed equally in the conduct of the government – weighted with no discrimination because of the content or source of the preferences
- Regime type has consequences. (Argues specifically for this claim in chapter 2 – although quite obvious, may be a useful early example of such)
- When military capacity is high and organized, polyarchy is impossible unless the military is sufficiently depoliticized such that it has neither intent nor ability to interfere with political discourse or dynamics.
- Farming societies largely differentiated into traditional peasant society, defined largely by hegemony, or a free farmer society, more aligned towards polyarchy.
- Though socioeconomic development seems in part to be linked to the prevalence of polyarchy – and it seems plausible that there exist upper and lower thresholds of economic development beyond which the probability of polyarchy remains constant – the relationship is neither clear, nor statedly causal, nor incredibly strong, nor without exception.
- Developed economies allow workers to be literate and more-educated, which in turn can expand their potential inclusion into the polyarchy – dual-directional effect. Advanced

economies cause pluralistic social orders, which in turn cause demands for a competitive political system (under one causal chain).

- “In an advanced economy, long-run performance under threat or coercion is less productive at all levels than a more willing performance based upon voluntary compliance.”
- Polyarchy seems to rest largely on mixed cooperative-competitive relationships: cooperate on the aspects of policy and governance whereupon common ground can be found, and compete on the others. In the absence of some cooperation, the trust and cohesion required for polyarchy cannot be sustained. But, in the absence of some conflict, the ability to retain a competitive political dynamic is greatly reduced.
- The historical association of polyarchy with capitalism called its value into question following the Great Depression, as its legitimacy was partially derailed. The explosion of single-party systems in the wake of this – including the acceleration of previously unstable single-party systems – can be partially attributed to this, as previous claims that polyarchy and democracy supported economic development became less clear.
- Three primary impacts of foreign involvement on polyarchy:
 1. Foreign actors can affect the beliefs of domestic actors, which we have already shown to be critical in establishing the conditions for (or against) polyarchy
 2. Foreign actors can affect the decision sets available to domestic political leaders; for example, Cold-War-style tension between US and USSR affecting the political outcomes of dependent countries
 3. Foreign actors can outright impose regime types or political systems on a domestic nation, either through conquest, coercion, or other similar means of domination

4 Connections

- “When hegemonic regimes and competitive oligarchies move toward polyarchy they increase the opportunities for effective participation and contestation and hence the number of individuals, groups, and interests whose preferences have to be considered in policymaking.” Indirect connection to Huntington 1968: increases participation, which per Huntington should result in instability unless there are additional institutions to handle it. Suggestion is that transition to polyarchy must involve a non-trivial movement towards institutional development as well.
- More Huntington 1968: agrees (indirectly) that parties begin to move away from tribal/familial/otherwise native sources of power and authority, and instead are replaced by those which are appealing to the middle classes
- Broad-scale oppression (i.e., Holocaust, USSR atrocities, etc.) do not happen in polyarchies, largely because the low barriers to contestation both allow marginalize groups

to better defend themselves politically and preemptively dissuade the state from pursuing or proposing any such aggressive policies

- Liberalization preceding inclusiveness – very much tied to A&R Why the West Extended the Franchise; essentially the same mechanism. Shortcut – very much tied to Huntington, although Dahl focuses more on mutual security than effective participation. See “three paths to polyarchy” in second section.
- Discussion of polyarchy as potentially losing legitimacy in the wake of the Great Depression, as previously it seemed to be a given that democracy drove economic development in some unilateral way – certainly goes back to Huntington, and also provides potentially some empirical backing to Huntington’s argument that democracy alone did not drive economic development (as well as the notion that voters actually internalized that lapse).
- Four primary factors in whether or not an individual adopts new political beliefs:
 1. Exposure: how much are they actually exposed to these new ideas? Is their political community well connected and civically engaged enough that this “contagion” could actually take place?
 2. Prestige: how prestigious is the new idea? Who are its proponents, and how much credit is given to their endorsement? Have the ideas been well-supported and either proven or disproven in high-profile settings?
 3. Consistency w/ beliefs: are the new beliefs consistent with the individual’s present beliefs? Tautologically, there must be some separation for this to be a meaningful shift, but are they aligned in principle or entirely separated? Do they fit into a common worldview and perhaps merely offer a differential explanation? (RG note: this could largely be tied to religious impacts on political beliefs, most notably Catholicism in modern western politics)
 4. Consistency w/ experience: are the new beliefs consistent with the policy-related (or even simply emotional) experiences the subject has endured? Do they align with previous needs/wants/solutions
- See Boix 1999: ruling parties can use the transition between majoritarianism and PR as a way of maintaining some degree of exclusivity (but possibly increasing contestation in part)
- Gourevitch 1978 expands particularly on the influence of foreign politics on domestic structures – Dahl notes that invasion can be a key factor in domestic politics, while Gourevitch acknowledges and significant expands upon this
- Schmitter 1974 discusses corporatism as a form of hegemonic politics and a limited range of inclusiveness

5 My Critiques

- One central claim seems to be that competitive politics universally dissuades coercion/repression etc. There is a world, though, where that argument does not necessarily stand. For example, in a reverse causal chain, if coercive capacity was quite high – such that the rents of holding office were similarly high – we might expect there to be more competition endogenously.